

BULLETIN

Number Thirty-four
February, 1971

Shortly after the news media carried the story of Timothy Leary's having taken refuge with the Panthers in Algeria, I received the following memo from Humphry Osmond (Dr. Osmond, as many readers will know, is the grand old man of psychedelic research; he is the man who turned on Aldous Huxley, and who invented the word "psychedelic"; and the man to whom I still turn when I want reliable, nonparanoid medical information on LSD). He headed his memo, "A Psychedelic Road?":

(dated 1 Nov. 1970)

It is almost exactly 10 years ago today, on the day of JFK's election, that Aldous Huxley, with whom I was staying in Cambridge, Mass., invited me to dine with him and a young Harvard Professor, Dr. Timothy Leary. As I recall it we met Timothy Leary in Boston; because it was election day we could take no alcoholic drinks. Aldous explained to me that Dr. Leary was planning well-planned scientific work in the department of psychology and would have the advice of Dr. John Spiegel, a well-known social psychiatrist. I was most curious to meet Dr. Leary. I recall that he wore a grey flannel suit, that his hair was crew cut, and that he was courteous, charming, and clearly deeply interested in his plans and prospects. I was not greatly impressed by his knowledge of psychedelics which seemed to be, as indeed it was, quite limited. However his main concern was to hear about the techniques which we had used and developed in Saskatchewan for treating alcoholics. He was interested in the group techniques which I described. I advised him to avoid schizophrenics and to screen out those who might suffer from this illness.

We sat some time after the meal and when we got back to Aldous' apartment we discussed the new recruit to our work. We were favorably impressed by his personal charm, frankness and sincerity. He seemed to have made sound plans and to be approaching the whole matter with gratifying sobriety. He was not very experienced. As we left him Aldous emphasized how necessary it was to "do good inconspicuously." Timothy nodded his crew cut head and gave his frank, straightforward smile, made all the more pleasing by his brilliant eyes.

Aldous was delighted that he was so sensible, down-to-earth, and clearly so aware of the problems which might lie ahead. I was in full agreement; such uneasiness as assailed me was whether such an obvious member of the Harvard establishment could cope with the problems. I wondered whether he would be adventurous enough. However I reminded myself that he would be working in the department founded by William James, which would encourage him towards what James himself called unhabitual perception. In this respect, if in no other, I was correct.

Aldous and I turned on the radio, and hearing that the MIT computers had already predicted, indeed one might have almost said proclaimed a Kennedy victory, we turned in, well contented with the events of that

PIC BULLETIN
is issued every
other month by Lisa
Bieberman, 26 Boylston St.,
Cambridge, Mass. 02138. Send
STAMPED, ADDRESSED ENVELOPES for
future issues. No subscriptions sold.

THE 6 RULES OF PHANEROTHYME: Do not take it more than
once in 3 months. Take it at least once a year.
Take it reverently. Plan the setting and group
carefully. Ask God's guidance before, during
and after. If phanerothyme gives
you a clear leading, carry it out -
but be sure it's clear.

memorable day, well before midnight.

Within about 18 months both Aldous and I had begun to revise our earlier opinion. We were quite opposed to Timothy's assertions that psychedelics could do no harm when guided properly and even more opposed to his view that the chemical composition of the substances involved was of little importance in comparison with the psycho-social setting. In 1962 I had reason to write to Timothy about one Michael H. who seemed to have had a prolonged reaction to large doses of psilocybin. Timothy took this very lightheartedly.

Aldous and I discussed the matter not long before his death when we met in Stockholm and both agreed that Timothy's growing missionary zeal was a most regrettable development. Indeed, I had a letter from Aldous asking whether I had any idea what Timothy was up to, for he was much concerned at his growing belief in the absolute correctness of his revelations. Although Timothy continued to revere Aldous and treated me with great cordiality, what has occurred since suggests that he took no notice whatever of our advice, which was at odds with his hugely expansive intuitive-oceanic temperament.

+ + + + +

My own first impressions of Dr. Leary were similar to Osmond's. I was a college undergraduate; he was a member of the faculty, and therefore, of the establishment. He had graying hair, sat behind a desk, wearing a business suit and a hearing aid, with a wire connecting it to the floor. Tim later underwent an operation to improve his hearing and the hearing aid disappeared, though I was sometimes to wonder whether he really heard, or wanted to hear, what was said to him. I think I have never met a man with whom it was more difficult to communicate.

Says Eldridge Cleaver now: "...it has become very clear to me that there's something seriously wrong with both Dr. Leary and his wife's brains. I attribute this to the multiple, the uncountable number of acid trips that they have taken... I find them both to be non-functional in a political context; not helpful, and really we have grown to look upon them sort of as patients." It seems that Tim's love of publicity ("Dr. Leary seems to wither away without an audience. He needs people around him who have a worshipful attitude towards him.") was felt by the Panthers to threaten the secrecy of their operations, and so they put Tim and Rosemary under house arrest, and announced their rejection of the "whole silly psychedelic drug culture." What they want, instead, is "men and women who fit the description given by Comrade Che Guevara: 'cool calculating killing machines to be turned against the enemy.'"

I was fascinated to see how one midwestern newspaper (thanks to friend George Moriarty of Canton, Ohio, who sends me things) editorialized on this "revolutionary bust." Here are two heroes of the counter-culture, among the men the U.S. government would most like to have behind bars. A conservative paper might have taken any of several editorial tacks on the incident of their falling out: it could have used it to discredit the Panther Party in the eyes of Leary admirers (Cleaver's remark about "cold, calculating killing machines" certainly leaves him open to this) or to criticize Cleaver for disloyalty to friends, or to put down all radicals on the grounds that they can't get along with one another. The paper chose to head its editorial, "Leary Crumbling?", and opines, "If drugs have eaten away at Leary's mind until it no longer can function normally, this information should be widely circulated. It might save many others who are following in his psychedelic footsteps." When it comes to putting down LSD, even Eldridge Cleaver will do as an authority. Mr. and Mrs. Amerika (in case anybody was wondering) would rather have their daughter marry a nigger than an acid freak.

Cleaver and the Canton Repository take the line usually adopted by Leary's critics, of attributing his eccentricities to heavy use of LSD.

There is probably a partial truth in this. Most heavy users, in my opinion, tend to be unrealistic and to be difficult to communicate with, and Leary was an extremely frequent user. If anybody's mind were to be "blown by acid" it would be his. To what extent this happened I can't be sure, because I didn't know him before he started using psychedelics. My early memories of Tim record some of the same grandiosity, non-sequitur logic, and carelessness of mundane facts and obligations that characterize his later behavior, and of course he had not taken so much in those days. It seems to me that his theories weren't quite so nonsensical in those days, but then he was dealing with an academic audience, not with a less learned public as in his days of fame, and perhaps he knew he couldn't get away with it at Harvard. To attribute Leary's personality entirely to acid is absurd, for there have been millions of LSD users and there has been only one Tim Leary.

The press made Leary leader of the psychedelic movement, though it's doubtful that more than a small fraction of LSD users were led by him at any given moment. He had an extraordinary combination of the ability to attract followers and the inability to get along with them once he had them. Tim always had a circle of admirers (and exploiters) around him, but it was never the same circle, for long. Tim couldn't stand permanent associates because they invariably expected him to follow through on his promises and announced plans, an intolerable constraint to Leary. Promises for him were not made to be kept, they were made to make the person addressed feel good, at the moment.

Leary could not function in cooperation with the Panthers for much the same reason he could not survive at Harvard University. People with concrete objectives cannot long relate to someone who does just as he pleases without regard to previous commitments or agreements. Leary's lifestyle would be completely non-functional, were it not for his personal magnetism, which has always served to draw to him disciples who would do his leg work and more or less take care of him. One of these was multi-millionaire William Mellon Hitchcock who for several years provided Tim with a home in the form of the haunted German-Gothic estate in Millbrook, New York, and surrounded him with the jet-set crowd that helped him maintain his image of sublime independence of worldly concerns; Hitchcock eventually withdrew his support when too many raids took place at Millbrook and he was in danger of getting into trouble as its owner. Leary was by then famous enough to count on support from New Left groups who saw him as a hero. But he may have run through his options. Who will free him from his liberators, now that they are disillusioned? Tim cannot run the Panthers' show, and he may be unable to relate to a scene that he cannot run.

Tim interprets his quarrel with Cleaver as demonstrating the incompatibility between LSD and the desire for power, and there may be something in this. Certainly acid will not help supply the killers Cleaver wants, for there is a tendency for users to become pacifists. But Tim's own psychedelic philosophy is tragically wrong, and in that respect he is a martyr for a very bad cause - the diabolical side of LSD. Two statements of Tim's made to me in the early sixties stand out in my mind as defining this philosophy. The occasion for the first was my asking him (perhaps with some irritation) why he hadn't done something that he had said, the day before, he would do "tomorrow"; Tim replied, "Lisa, the universe is an ecstatic dance of whirling electrons!" The other was during a conversation at Millbrook, a remark later repeated in a lecture: "You can't do good unless you feel good."

This was the world Tim offered his followers: a world of whirling electrons without a solid place to stand, in which the search for the elusive "feeling good" had top priority. (An echo comes to mind from a telephone conversation with a girl in California, in which I questioned the relevance of "Be-Ins" to the needs of the psychedelic movement; she said, "You can't stop the dance. You can't stop the dance. You can't stop the dance.") In 1965 when Tim married his second wife Nina, he told me, "I'm

retiring from public life. I'm going to try very hard to save my soul." But in all his trips Tim never found the solid place, and the dance went on.

Tim put forth a theory about levels of consciousness, and said that there was a drug corresponding to each level. The highest of these was the one large doses of LSD took you to: the "molecular level" in which reality is seen as whirling particles. I think Tim really believes that is the ultimate reality. Did he get this idea from LSD, or did he absorb it in his youth from the reductionist worldviews of his generation? Perhaps the one reinforced the other. For there is an LSD trip into a world of heartless flux, of untrackable particulate wilderness. It is usually referred to as hell. The mystery is why anybody would want to keep going there. Most people, after one or two such trips, have had enough. There is also the hell Tim calls the "cellular level" - sheer biological process without morality or higher purpose. There is no place for human love, purpose, or faithfulness on these levels, for human beings do not exist, they are resolved into processes. Still less is there any place for a God of love. Tim maintained that "God is the DNA code."

Timothy knew that the God of historical revelation was the enemy of his philosophy. "Walk carefully when you are among...Christians and Jews," he wrote at the end of his Psychedelic Prayers from the Tao Te Ching, a collection of rapturous invocations to the energy dance he revered, "for such as these...addict you to their externals, distract you from the Tao within." In High Priest he tells of two Christians who, having been turned on, tried to convert him. They begged Tim to be humble and to get down on his knees; the way in which he recounts the incident reveals his scorn for this idea.

I have often wondered how the social reaction to psychedelics would have developed had it not been for this man. Would the establishment have been less frightened of LSD, and repression therefore forestalled? Or would the repression have been all the more complete because fewer people would have known about LSD. Would a different sort of leader have emerged who could have inspired a different and sounder vision - for Leary's philosophy is not, as most people suppose, the inevitable result of the LSD experience, but is the product of the mind of one man, on a trip that left out Christ.

It is hard for me to be fair to Leary. He took a thing I had come to cherish and sold it to the devil. The fact remains that those in power, who never knew the difference, have persecuted him shockingly, and would probably have done the same to me had I had his place in the spotlight. Anyone who let the inhuman prison sentences handed out to Leary for possessing scraps of marijuana go by without a protest because they abhorred his views doesn't know the meaning of civil liberties or freedom of speech.

I sent a copy of the letter, that I had originally sent Tim via Rosemary in Berkeley and printed in the August '70 Bulletin, to an Algerian address that Mike Aldrich gave me. But I still don't know whether Tim got it.

The text of Eldridge Cleaver's remarks, and of a three-way interview among Cleaver, Leary and Michael Zwerin of the Village Voice is reprinted in the February 5 issue of the Berkeley Barb.

* * * * *

Literature available from PIC:

SESSION GAMES PEOPLE PLAY - A Manual for the Use of LSD. \$1.

PHANEROTHYME - A Western Approach to the Religious Use of Psychochemicals. 75¢

"What God Is Doing with Drugs" (talk given at Wilmington College, Ohio). 25¢

TWO YEARS IN THE PSYCHEDELIC MOVEMENT - 1965-67 (Bulletins 1-12 with notes) \$1.50

Individual back issues of the Bulletin from #13 through #33. 10¢ each

Please send money with order.